

Utilizing the CSAC Survey to Study Issues Impacting Transgender Students: A Short Research Summary

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1 Background

The California Student Aid Commission (CSAC) is the state agency that is responsible for administering financial aid programs for postsecondary education. In 2020, CSAC partnered with the California Education Lab (Ed Lab) at University of California, Davis to conduct a survey on the experiences of college students and high school seniors during the COVID pandemic. For the 2023-2024 academic year, the survey is pivoting away from COVID-19 topics and towards more general questions about the student experience with college and financial aid. As a graduate student researcher for the Ed Lab, I am joining the project and now have the potential opportunity to propose several additional questions to include in the survey.

2 Opportunities and Challenges

The key opportunity presented by the CSAC student survey is the sheer sample size, which presents a unique opportunity to study LGBTQ+ students, who will comprise a subgroup with sufficient size given the size of the population. The survey is sent via email to all students in California who file or renew a FAFSA application for the year. There are two waves of the survey: the spring survey, which is sent to high school seniors and first-time adult college students who file their FAFSA applications; and the fall survey, which is sent to current college students who file FAFSA renewals. In addition, starting in the 2022-2023 academic year, California AB 469 requires all high school seniors to complete a FAFSA application, therefore, we expect to see an increase in the number of high school seniors who answer the survey this year.

In the 2019-2020 academic year, there were around 2.4 million FAFSA filers in California, and for the 2020 CSAC student survey, there were around 200,000 responses which gives us a response rate of 10%. Assuming 2% are transgender and 3% are non-binary ¹, this yields a sample size of 4000 transgender students and 6000 non-binary students in the sample. Additionally, assuming 6.6% are gay, lesbian, or bisexual, this would yield a sample of 13200 students ². Using statistics reported by the Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System (BRFSS) (Lee Badgett et al., 2021) as a conservative estimate and half the response rate at 5%, we still arrive at a sample of 3000 lesbian, gay, and bisexual students and a sample of 500 transgender students. This is a rare opportunity to work with a large sample of LGBTQ+ students.

The key challenge, however, is that students do not receive any compensation for the survey. Due to the large sample size, we are not able to properly incentivize survey participants. Another challenge is that the survey questions need to be related to student financial aid or the students' college experience, however, this requirement is arguably easier to satisfy. Finally, the survey length is another constraint. Since students are not receiving compensation, we need to keep the survey relatively short to reduce the possibility of respondents exiting the survey halfway. This limits the number and types of experiments/interventions that are possible.

3 Preliminary Proposal

3.1 Question 1

There are two main questions I am interested in studying, and which I believe would be suitable given the context and the characteristics of the survey. The first is to investigate the discriminatory attitudes towards transgender peers in college. Trans and gender nonconforming youth face a variety of challenges at school, including but not limited to access to gender-congruent bathrooms, ability to play on sports teams, bullying and harassment from peers, and discriminatory policies and actions from teachers and administrators that disrespect their gender identity and expression, and that which often leads to disciplinary actions against trans students³. According to the 2021 GLSEN National School Climate Survey, around 74% of transgender students reported feeling unsafe

¹Statistics from Pew Research Center: <https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2022/06/07/about-5-of-young-adults-in-the-u-s-say-their-gender-is-different-from-their-sex-assigned-at-birth/>

²Statistics from Gallup: <https://news.gallup.com/poll/470708/lgbt-identification-steady.aspx>

³National Center for Transgender Equality: <https://transequality.org/issues/youth-students>

at school⁴. With the rapidly increasing number of anti-trans bills being introduced or passed in state legislatures across the country, the difficulties that transgender students face are likely to persist and worsen. There has been relatively few studies documenting the discriminatory attitudes of college students towards their transgender peers, and learning more about these attitudes can reveal valuable information about the college environment for policy makers. Since attitudes towards transgender people are sensitive issues, I plan to use a double list experiment to circumvent the social desirability bias problem (Glynn, 2013; Aksoy et al., 2022). The two key statements I plan to include are:

1. I would be comfortable having a transgender roommate who is the same gender as me
2. I would be comfortable having a transgender coworker

3.2 Question 2

The second research question is whether anti-transgender discriminator attitudes can be reduced by an intervention through perspective-taking (Bertrand and Duflo, 2017). Perspective taking is an intervention developed by psychologists and involves "stepping into the shoes of a stereotyped person and can be useful in assessing the emotional impact on individuals who are constantly being stereotyped in negative ways" (Bertrand and Duflo, 2017). This intervention targets emotions, which have been shown to be a powerful driver behind beliefs and attitudes, and studies have shown that perspective taking can reduce prejudice in implicit attitudes and in-person interactions (Shih et al., 2009; Todd et al., 2011). The preliminary instrument for this intervention would involve a video clip showing a transgender student activist testifying against an anti-trans bill in a state legislature. In the treatment, participants would be asked to write a few short sentences describing how they imagine the trans person in the video might feel from the discriminatory attitudes and rhetoric. To avoid salience effects, in the control group participants would be shown a neutral news video about the same piece of legislation. This intervention can be implemented early in the survey and the outcome measurement can be the results from double list experiment for research question 1 (this would be a 2×2 design). Another possibility is an IAT at the end of the survey, however, survey length might be a binding constraint.

⁴2021 GLSEN National School Climate Survey: <https://www.glsen.org/research/2021-national-school-climate-survey>

3.3 Other Questions

I described these above two questions first because I believe they are the more feasible ones, however, I have a number of other research questions that are pertinent and interesting. First, I would like to study trust and taste-based discrimination against gender and sexual minorities, using a similar design as (Fershtman and Gneezy, 2001). This would involve trust games and dictator games. Second, I am interested in the extent of inaccurate beliefs about gender and sexual minorities and how it impacts (inaccurate) statistical discrimination. This would involve the participants performing a task, as well as some variation of a hiring game and belief elicitations. Third, it would be interesting to replicate and extend (Aksoy et al., 2022) to study the self-confidence and patterns in belief updating about self evaluations among gender and sexual minorities, with finer subgroup analysis given the advantage of the larger sample. This would involve some type of real effort task that measure a proxy of ability or intelligence, as well as belief elicitations. Last but not least, I believe it would be interesting to study whether there are any differences in competitiveness and risk preferences between gender and sexual minorities and their cisgender, heterosexual peers. Again this would require real effort tasks. The main challenge common to all of the above questions is that they require proper incentives. Without the ability to provide monetary incentives, it would be difficult to ensure the validity of the experiments.

4 Conclusion

The CSAC student survey provides a unique and rare opportunity to access a large sample of sexual and gender minority students and offers great potential for conducting research on issues impacting these populations. However, the main challenges are the lack of monetary incentives, and the limitations on the length and types of questions in the survey. I have provided a brief description of some research questions that I believe are feasible and a preliminary design for them, as well as several other questions that are equally, if not more, interesting and important, but which are unfortunately less feasible given the constraints. As a trans woman myself, I believe it is my responsibility to do whatever I can to help my community, and this is an opportunity for me to utilize my position as a researcher to do so. I hope I was able to convey my ideas clearly, and I look forward to discussing in person.

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